said. ‘Valmikis in the state had suffered under Tipu in the eighteenth century and they came to us. Many people got into discovering us because of the BJP and realised that most issues are not political but social. So, they went to RSS thereafter.’[41]

Power acts as a powerful recruitment tool. Karnataka’s example is not unique. In Haryana, when M.L. Khattar of the RSS was made chief minister in 2014, the Sangh grew stronger in the state. Journalist Manvir Saini observed that as ‘stories of Khattar spending time with another Swayamsevak, PM Narendra Modi, in their earlier years started circulating, many were attracted’. As a result, the number of RSS shakhas in Haryana rose by over 400 per cent—from nearly 400 in 2014 to about 1,700 (covering 6,909 villages) by 2017.[42] In just over three years, a state that had been a lukewarm area for the RSS had shakha penetration almost as dense as Gujarat’s. By 2017, Gujarat, with a population of about 6 crore, had 3,500 shakhas, while Haryana, with a population of 2.5 crore, had grown to 1,700 shakhas.[43]

The numbers clearly show that Modi’s national victories in 2014 and 2019 also served to strengthen the RSS. According to RSS Saha Sarkaryavaha (Joint General Secretary) Manmohan Vaidya, between 2014 and 2016, an average of 90,000–95,000 Indians put in requests to join the RSS every year.[44] This, he claimed, went up to 1,25,000 in 2017; 1,50,000 in 2018, and stood at 1,30,000 as of September 2019. Crucially, even as the RSS expanded its footprint, it was also claiming a younger demographic. As Vaidya said in Bhubaneshwar in October 2019, students and youth were running 60 per cent of all shakhas. The number of shakhas run by individuals above the age of forty, he said, stood at just 11 per cent. This ‘partially explains the rise of vote share for BJP among the first-time voters,’ he said emphatically.[45]

How Much RSS in the BJP: 50:50

The RSS has a complicated relationship with power. It does not formally take part in politics—indeed, that has been a cardinal principle for the Sangh since its inception. As Chapter 9 shows, the RSS’s second sarsanghchalak (chief), M.S. Golwalkar, counselled